

The Country of the Blind

H. G. Wells · 1904

First published: The Strand, Apr 1904

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Country_of_the_Blind_and_Other_Stories/The_Country_of_the_Blind (revision 15022019), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Country of the Blind suggest about perception and truth?
- What does The Country of the Blind suggest about conformity?
- What does The Country of the Blind suggest about arrogance?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one

essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.

Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Country of the Blind	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*perception and truth* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Country of the Blind

Author biography

H. G. Wells was born in Bromley, Kent, on 21 September 1866, the son of a shopkeeper and a housekeeper. He was apprenticed to a draper, won a scholarship to study science under T. H. Huxley in London, and became a teacher and journalist. The Time Machine (1895), The Invisible Man (1897) and The War of the Worlds (1898) helped found modern science fiction; he later wrote social stories, a best-selling Outline of History and campaigned for world government. He died in London on 13 August 1946.

Historical and cultural context

The story is set in the Andes of Ecuador, at the height of the age of exploration and empire, when Europeans assumed their own superiority. Wells was interested in evolution and how communities adapt.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The Strand Magazine in April 1904; Wells revised it in 1939 with a different ending.

Then: Admired as one of Wells's best stories.

Now: Read as a parable about perception, conformity and cultural arrogance.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Nunez, a mountaineer, falls into a hidden Andean valley where everyone has been blind for generations. He expects to rule, recalling the proverb "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King."

Main themes

- perception and truth.
- conformity.
- cultural arrogance.

Why it matters

It asks how communities treat difference, and whether "normal" is relative.

Spoilers · teacher only

The villagers think his sight a delusion; to marry the woman he loves he must have his eyes removed. He flees up the mountain, and in the 1904 version lies down content, probably to die.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Country of the Blind: Is there something you can do that others don't value at all?
Prompt: Before we open The Country of the Blind: Is there something you can do that others don't value at all?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

parable; irony; satire; conformity.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. H. G. Wells was born in Bromley, Kent, on 21 September 1866, the son of a shopkeeper and a housekeeper. He was apprenticed to a draper, won a scholarship to study science under T. H. Huxley in London, and became a teacher and journalist. The Time Machine (1895), The Invisible Man (1897) and The War of the Worlds (1898) helped found modern science fiction; he later wrote social stories, a best-selling Outline of History and campaigned for world government. He died in London on 13 August 1946. The world of the book. The story is set in the Andes of Ecuador, at the height of the age of exploration and empire, when Europeans assumed their own superiority. Wells was interested in evolution and how communities adapt. Publication and reception. First published in The Strand Magazine in April 1904; Wells revised it in 1939 with a different ending. Then: Admired as one of Wells's best stories. Now: Read as a parable about perception, conformity and cultural arrogance.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19). The proverb he repeats.

> *In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19)*

Think-aloud: "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19). The proverb he repeats.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Nunez, a mountaineer, falls into a hidden Andean valley where everyone has been blind for generations. He expects to rule, recalling the proverb "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King." Themes to track: perception and truth.: conformity.: cultural arrogance.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Country of the Blind: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Country of the Blind still matter? It asks how communities treat difference, and whether "normal" is relative.
Anchor question: Why might The Country of the Blind still be taught today?
Facilitation: It asks how communities treat difference, and whether "normal" is relative.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why does the proverb turn out to be wrong? Answer: The blind world is fully adapted to blindness; sight brings no power where no one values it.
Exit ticket: Why does the proverb turn out to be wrong?
Answer: The blind world is fully adapted to blindness; sight brings no power where no one values it.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Country of the Blind.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "H. G. Wells" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/H-G-Wells); H. G. Wells Society (https://hgwellssociety.com/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Verify the first-publication month; some sources give The Strand, April 1904. The 1939 revised ending differs.

Lesson 2: The Country of the Blind

Focus: the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

Objective: Students will analyze how irony develops in “The Country of the Blind” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (threat of forced surgery): Sensitive content: Threat of forced surgery. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes threat of forced surgery.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Mountaineer Nunez falls into an isolated Andean valley whose people have been blind for fifteen generations and no longer believe in sight. He expects 'In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King' but is treated as a madman. He falls in love with Medina-saroté; the elders agree to the marriage if his eyes, thought to be diseased, are removed. On the morning of the operation he climbs out of the valley and lies smiling under the stars.

Background: Published in The Strand in 1904; the valley's beliefs satirize how communities enforce their own 'truth'.

Significance: Often paired with Plato's allegory of the cave in discussing perception and conformity.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it better to fit in or to keep a truth others reject? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to conformity because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes threat of forced surgery.
Prompt: Is it better to fit in or to keep a truth others reject?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to conformity because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the valley wants to "cure" his difference.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
*Today's words: converged — came together from different directions; cascade — a falling mass, like a waterfall; glaciers — huge slow-moving masses of ice; avalanche — a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain; mockingly — in a disrespectful jeering manner. "converged": From Latin convergere, from con- + vergere. "cascade": From French cascade, from Italian cascata, from cascare "to fall", from Vulgar Latin *cāsicāre, derived from Latin cadere, ultimately from Proto-Indo-European *ḱh₂d-.*
Words: converged: came together from different directions · cascade: a falling mass, like a waterfall · glaciers: huge slow-moving masses of ice · avalanche: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain · mockingly: in a disrespectful jeering manner

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in The Strand in 1904; the valley's beliefs satirize how communities enforce their own 'truth'. Often paired with Plato's allegory of the cave in discussing perception and conformity. Irony: The proverb is reversed. Setting: The isolated valley is a fully adapted world. Characterization: Nunez begins arrogant and ends humbled. Watch for sight: truth and individuality.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19). The proverb. That is irony at work: The proverb is reversed.

> *In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King* *(The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19). The proverb. That is irony at work: The proverb is reversed.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: His arrogance. Look at the craft: The isolated valley is a fully adapted world. Ask: How does this line connect to conformity? Expected: The valley wants to "cure" his difference. (His arrogance.)

> *I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see* *(The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: His arrogance. Look at the craft: The isolated valley is a fully adapted world.
Ask: How does this line connect to conformity?
Expected answer: The valley wants to "cure" his difference. (His arrogance.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for irony, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Country of the Blind develops the idea of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. When the text says "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197), it shows this directly. Nunez repeats "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King," but the villagers see him as deluded and want to remove his eyes; finally, on the mountain, "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote."

Task: Annotate the story for irony, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Country of the Blind develops the idea of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. When the text says "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197), it shows this directly. Nunez repeats "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King," but the villagers see him as deluded and want to remove his eyes; finally, on the mountain, "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: Is it better to fit in or to keep a truth others reject? Ask: would you give up a sense for love?

Anchor question: Is it better to fit in or to keep a truth others reject?

Facilitation: Ask: would you give up a sense for love?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. ("He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote", The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. ("He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote", The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how irony shapes the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Key takeaway: the valley wants to "cure" his difference.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** The proverb is reversed.
- **Setting:** The isolated valley is a fully adapted world.
- **Characterization:** Nunez begins arrogant and ends humbled.

Themes and how they develop

- **conformity:** the valley wants to "cure" his difference.

Symbols and motifs

- **sight:** truth and individuality.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19) The proverb.
- "I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55) His arrogance.
- "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197) His final choice of sight over love.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

> **Claim:** Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior.
> **Evidence:** "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197)
> **Reasoning:** Nunez repeats "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King," but the villagers see him as deluded and want to remove his eyes; finally, on the mountain, "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
converged (verb)		*He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the*	

	came together from different directions	*meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upon him. "I'll hit them if they touch me," he swore; "by Heaven, I will.*	"converged": From Latin convergere, from con- + vergere. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/converge#Etymology)
cascade (noun)	a falling mass, like a waterfall	*He descended a steep place, and so came to the wall and channel that ran about the valley, near where the latter spouted out its surplus contents into the deeps of the gorge in a thin and wavering thread of cascade.*	"cascade": From French cascade, from Italian cascata, from cascare "to fall", from Vulgar Latin *cāsicāre, derived from Latin cadere, ultimately from Proto-Indo-European *ḱh₂d-. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cascade#Etymology)
glaciers (noun)	huge slow-moving masses of ice	*Over mountains and glaciers; right over above there, half-way to the sun.*	
avalanche (noun)	a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain	*He had slipped eastward towards the unknown side of the mountain; far below he had struck a steep slope of snow, and ploughed his way down it in the midst of a snow avalanche.*	
mockingly (adverb)	in a disrespectful jeering manner	*A little boy nipped his hand. "Bogota!" he said mockingly.*	
disappointing (verb)	failing to give someone what they hope for	*But Nunez's manner of receiving the good news struck him as being cold and disappointing.*	
simultaneous (adjective)	occurring or operating at the same time	*They startled him by a simultaneous movement towards him, each with a hand outstretched.*	"simultaneous": From Medieval Latin simultaneus, from simultim "at the same time, extended", from Latin simul "together, at the same time"; compare similar. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/simultaneous#Etymology)
starlight (noun)	the light of the stars	*Once at a rest-day gathering they sat side by side in the dim starlight, and the music was sweet.*	"starlight": From star + light. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/starlight#Etymology)
civilly (adverb)	in a civil manner	*And very civilly he gave them greeting.*	"civilly": From Middle English cyvyly, equivalent to civil + -ly. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/civilly#Etymology)

precipices (noun)	a very steep cliff	*The gorge between these precipices ran east and west and was full of the morning sunlight, which lit to the westward the mass of fallen mountain that closed the descending gorge.*	"precipices": First attested in 1598, from Middle French precipice, from Latin praecipitium "a steep place", from praeceps "steep", from prae + caput "head", ultimately from Proto-Indo-European *kap- "head". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/precipice#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Is it better to fit in or to keep a truth others reject?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with perception and truth?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How does Nunez enter the valley? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: He falls during a mountain climb
2. What proverb does Nunez repeat? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King
3. How do the villagers treat his claims about sight? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: As the ravings of a madman
4. Whom does Nunez want to marry? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Medina-saroté
5. What must he give up to marry? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: His eyes
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Country of the Blind" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Mountaineer Nunez falls into an isolated Andean valley whose people have been blind for fifteen generations and no longer believe in sight. He expects 'In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King' but is treated as a madman. He falls in love with Medina-saroté; the elders agree to the marriage if his eyes, thought to be diseased, are removed. On the morning of the operation he climbs out…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Country of the Blind"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Country of the Blind" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.

9. Reread: “He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upon him. "I'll hit them if they touch me," he swore; "by Heaven, I will.” What does “converged” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: converged: came together from different directions.
10. Reread: “He descended a steep place, and so came to the wall and channel that ran about the valley, near where the latter spouted out its surplus contents into the deeps of the gorge in a thin and wavering thread of cascade.” What does “cascade” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: cascade: a falling mass, like a waterfall.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Country of the Blind” suggest about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Often paired with Plato's allegory of the cave in discussing perception and conformity.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19): The proverb. On setting: The isolated valley is a fully adapted world. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “Nunez had an eye for all beautiful things, and it seemed to him that the glow upon the snowfields and glaciers that rose about the valley on every side was the most beautiful…”, why might Wells have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Country of the Blind”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Mountaineer Nunez falls into an isolated Andean valley whose people have been blind for fifteen generations and no longer believe in sight. He expects 'In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King' but is treated as a madman. He falls in love with Medina-saroté; the elders agree to the…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Country of the Blind” set up that the rest of The Country of the Blind will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55): His arrogance. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted

line.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197): His final choice of sight over love. On characterization: Nunez begins arrogant and ends humbled. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it better to fit in or to keep a truth others reject?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does theme appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with perception and truth? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Look for statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19): The proverb. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in The Strand in 1904; the valley's beliefs satirize how communities enforce their own 'truth'. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55): His arrogance. On setting: The isolated valley is a fully adapted world. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Often paired with Plato's allegory of the cave in discussing perception and conformity.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197): His final choice of sight over love. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19): The proverb. On characterization: Nunez begins arrogant and ends humbled. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of “The Country of the Blind” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55): His arrogance. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Country of the Blind”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197): His final choice of sight over love. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to conformity: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Wells need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19): The proverb. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55): His arrogance. On irony: The proverb is reversed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “The Country of the Blind” treats the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Country of the Blind see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197): His final choice of sight over love. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve perception and truth? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King” (The Country of the

Blind, paragraph 19): The proverb. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55): His arrogance. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask H. G. Wells about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Useful evidence: “He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197): His final choice of sight over love. Theme link: the valley wants to "cure" his difference. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Theme**: statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197: “He _____ of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote”
   Key: thought
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “They startled him by a _____ movement towards him, each with a hand outstretched.” Word bank: glaciers, cascade, converged, simultaneous
   Key: simultaneous
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whom does Nunez want to marry?
   A. Medina-saroté
   B. No one
   C. Yacob's wife
   D. A shepherd girl
   Key: A (Medina-saroté)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19: “In the _____ of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King”
   Key: Country

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How do the villagers treat his claims about sight?

   A. With fear

   B. With reverence

   C. They make him king

   D. As the ravings of a madman

   Key: D (As the ravings of a madman)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What proverb does Nunez repeat?

   A. Seeing is believing

   B. Love is blind

   C. Pride goes before a fall

   D. In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King

   Key: D (In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Once at a rest-day gathering they sat side by side in the dim _____, and the music was sweet." Word bank: glaciers, starlight, cascade, converged
   Key: starlight

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "But Nunez's manner of receiving the good news struck him as being cold and _____." Word bank: disappointing, glaciers, converged, cascade
   Key: disappointing

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Nunez enter the valley?

   A. He is captured

   B. He is invited

   C. He falls during a mountain climb

   D. He follows a river

   Key: C (He falls during a mountain climb)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What must he give up to marry?

    A. His name

    B. His language

    C. His freedom to climb

    D. His eyes

    Key: D (His eyes)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The proverb.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see" (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: His arrogance.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Country of the Blind"?

    A. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

    B. Human limits in an indifferent nature

    C. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

D. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

Key: D (The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: His final choice of sight over love.
15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Country of the Blind”? The proverb is reversed.
    A. Simile
    B. Hyperbole
    C. Irony
    D. Tone / mood

    Key: C (Irony)
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how conformity develops from an earlier story to “The Country of the Blind”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: the valley wants to "cure" his difference.
17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197).
    Sample answer: Nunez repeats "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King," but the villagers see him as deluded and want to remove his eyes; finally, on the mountain, "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote."
18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “A little boy nipped his hand. "Bogota!" he said _____.” Word bank: converged, cascade, glaciers, mockingly
    Key: mockingly
19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Country of the Blind”? The isolated valley is a fully adapted world.
    A. Setting
    B. Metaphor
    C. Foreshadowing
    D. Characterization

    Key: A (Setting)
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Nunez repeats "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King," but the villagers see him as deluded and want to remove his eyes; finally, on the mountain, "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote."
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I come from the great world— where men have eyes and see” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: His arrogance.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The proverb.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He descended a steep place, and so came to the wall and channel that ran about the valley, near where the latter spouted out its surplus contents into the deeps of the gorge in a thin and wavering thread of cascade.”, what does “cascade” most nearly mean?

    A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    B. came together from different directions

    C. huge slow-moving masses of ice

    D. a falling mass, like a waterfall

    Key: D (a falling mass, like a waterfall)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He had slipped eastward towards the unknown side of the mountain; far below he had struck a steep slope of snow, and ploughed his way down it in the midst of a snow avalanche.”, what does “avalanche” most nearly mean?

    A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    B. huge slow-moving masses of ice

    C. a falling mass, like a waterfall

    D. came together from different directions

    Key: A (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Over mountains and glaciers; right over above there, half-way to the sun.”, what does “glaciers” most nearly mean?

    A. a falling mass, like a waterfall

    B. came together from different directions

    C. huge slow-moving masses of ice

    D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    Key: C (huge slow-moving masses of ice)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upon him. "I'll hit them if they touch me," he swore; "by Heaven, I will.”, what does “converged” most nearly mean?

    A. huge slow-moving masses of ice

    B. came together from different directions

    C. a falling mass, like a waterfall

    D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    Key: B (came together from different directions)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	7, 1, 4, 6, 9, 10, 8, 3, 2, 12, 13, 11, 15, 17, 14, 16	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 3, 10, 9, 2, 18, 6, 4, 13, 12, 11, 15, 17, 19, 20, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2

HS Junior	18, 2, 1, 10, 8, 9, 3, 12, 13, 11, 15, 14, 17, 19, 21, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	2, 7, 4, 10, 18, 9, 12, 11, 13, 17, 15, 19, 14, 16, 21, 20	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	10, 2, 3, 7, 4, 11, 13, 12, 14, 15, 17, 19, 22, 16, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	18, 23, 6, 7, 24, 11, 13, 12, 14, 19, 17, 15, 16, 22, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	18, 24, 1, 23, 9, 11, 13, 12, 17, 15, 19, 14, 22, 16, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	5, 25, 10, 8, 7, 13, 12, 11, 19, 14, 15, 17, 21, 20, 16, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	9, 4, 1, 3, 18, 12, 13, 11, 19, 14, 17, 15, 21, 20, 22, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	7, 5, 4, 3, 26, 11, 13, 12, 14, 15, 19, 17, 21, 16, 20, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Country of the Blind,” how does Wells show the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): In The Country of the Blind, how does Wells develop the idea of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Country of the Blind develops the idea of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of The Country of the Blind (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what The Country of the Blind suggests about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how H. G. Wells uses irony in The Country of the Blind to complicate the reader's understanding of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Country of the Blind within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary

perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Country of the Blind alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Country of the Blind and its treatment of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Country of the Blind as evidence for a larger claim about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently in The Country of the Blind. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Country of the Blind as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Country of the Blind.

SAT-style questions

1. *Over mountains and glaciers; right over above there, half-way to the sun.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “glaciers” most nearly mean?

   A. huge slow-moving masses of ice

   B. a very steep cliff

   C. in a civil manner

   D. the light of the stars

2. *Nunez had an eye for all beautiful things, and it seemed to him that the glow upon the snowfields and glaciers that rose about the valley on every side was the most beautiful thing he had ever seen. His eyes went from that inaccessible glory to the village and irrigated fields, fast sinking into the twilight, and suddenly a wave of emotion took him, and he thanked God from the bottom of his heart that the power of sight had been given him.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Country of the Blind”?

   A. The futile attempt to shut out death

   B. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

   C. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

   D. The hunter becoming the hunted

SAT key: 1. A (huge slow-moving masses of ice); 2. C (The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently)

Unit test

The Country of the Blind: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Once at a rest-day gathering they sat side by side in the dim _____, and the music was sweet.” Word bank: glaciers, starlight, cascade, converged
   Key: starlight
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Nunez enter the valley?
   A. He is captured
   B. He is invited
   C. He falls during a mountain climb
   D. He follows a river

   Key: C (He falls during a mountain climb)
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197: “He _____ of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote”
   Key: thought
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What must he give up to marry?
   A. His name
   B. His language
   C. His freedom to climb
   D. His eyes

   Key: D (His eyes)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What proverb does Nunez repeat?
   A. Seeing is believing
   B. Love is blind
   C. Pride goes before a fall
   D. In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King

   Key: D (In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King)
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How do the villagers treat his claims about sight?
   A. With fear

B. With reverence

C. They make him king

D. As the ravings of a madman

Key: D (As the ravings of a madman)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “A little boy nipped his hand. "Bogota!" he said _____.” Word bank: converged, cascade, glaciers, mockingly

   Key: mockingly

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “But Nunez's manner of receiving the good news struck him as being cold and _____.” Word bank: disappointing, glaciers, converged, cascade

   Key: disappointing

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whom does Nunez want to marry?

   A. Medina-saroté

   B. No one

   C. Yacob's wife

   D. A shepherd girl

   Key: A (Medina-saroté)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19: “In the _____ of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King”

    Key: Country

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “They startled him by a _____ movement towards him, each with a hand outstretched.” Word bank: glaciers, cascade, converged, simultaneous

    Key: simultaneous

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: His arrogance.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The proverb.

14. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Country of the Blind”?

    A. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

    B. Human limits in an indifferent nature

    C. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

    D. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

    Key: D (The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Country of the Blind”? The isolated valley is a fully adapted world.

    A. Setting

    B. Metaphor

    C. Foreshadowing

    D. Characterization

Key: A (Setting)

16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Country of the Blind”? The proverb is reversed.

    A. Simile

    B. Hyperbole

    C. Irony

    D. Tone / mood

    Key: C (Irony)

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: His final choice of sight over love.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Nunez repeats "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King," but the villagers see him as deluded and want to remove his eyes; finally, on the mountain, "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote."

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Wells overturns Nunez's belief that sight makes him superior. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 197).

    Sample answer: Nunez repeats "In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King," but the villagers see him as deluded and want to remove his eyes; finally, on the mountain, "He thought of Medina-saroté, and she had become small and remote."

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 19) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The proverb.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I come from the great world—where men have eyes and see” (The Country of the Blind, paragraph 55) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: His arrogance.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how conformity develops from an earlier story to “The Country of the Blind”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: the valley wants to "cure" his difference.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He had slipped eastward towards the unknown side of the mountain; far below he had struck a steep slope of snow, and ploughed his way down it in the midst of a snow avalanche.”, what does “avalanche” most nearly mean?

    A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    B. huge slow-moving masses of ice

    C. a falling mass, like a waterfall

    D. came together from different directions

    Key: A (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He descended a steep place, and so came to the wall and channel that ran about the valley, near where the latter spouted out its surplus contents into the deeps of the gorge in a thin and wavering thread of cascade.”, what does “cascade” most nearly mean?

    A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    B. came together from different directions

    C. huge slow-moving masses of ice

    D. a falling mass, like a waterfall

    Key: D (a falling mass, like a waterfall)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upon him. "I'll hit them if they touch me," he swore; "by Heaven, I will.”, what does “converged” most nearly mean?

    A. huge slow-moving masses of ice

    B. came together from different directions

    C. a falling mass, like a waterfall

    D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    Key: B (came together from different directions)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Over mountains and glaciers; right over above there, half-way to the sun.”, what does “glaciers” most nearly mean?

    A. a falling mass, like a waterfall

    B. came together from different directions

    C. huge slow-moving masses of ice

    D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    Key: C (huge slow-moving masses of ice)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	9, 5, 3, 6, 4, 10, 1, 2, 8, 11, 7, 14, 12, 13, 19, 17, 15, 20	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	8, 1, 10, 4, 2, 5, 11, 9, 7, 6, 12, 14, 13, 16, 19, 15, 20, 21	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	2, 4, 5, 10, 8, 1, 9, 3, 7, 12, 14, 13, 19, 15, 16, 17, 21, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	10, 6, 7, 8, 2, 11, 3, 9, 14, 13, 12, 19, 16, 17, 15, 20, 22, 21	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	5, 10, 8, 23, 4, 24, 6, 13, 14, 12, 16, 19, 15, 17, 22, 20, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	6, 4, 8, 25, 7, 24, 26, 14, 12, 13, 19, 17, 15, 16, 20, 21, 18, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	4, 23, 9, 2, 10, 5, 11, 12, 14, 13, 15, 19, 17, 16, 20, 18, 21, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	2, 8, 3, 10, 11, 26, 1, 14, 12, 13, 15, 19, 17, 16, 22, 20, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	2, 7, 8, 25, 10, 3, 5, 14, 13, 12, 16, 19, 17, 15, 21, 18, 20, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	7, 26, 8, 6, 23, 5, 9, 13, 14, 12, 15, 19, 16, 17, 21, 22, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Country of the Blind: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how H. G. Wells develops perception and truth across The Country of the Blind. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Country of the Blind and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to conformity.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Country of the Blind. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Country of the Blind finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of arrogance. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Perception and truth

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Country of the Blind teaches about perception and truth. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how H. G. Wells develops perception and truth in The Country of the Blind. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how H. G. Wells develops perception and truth across The Country of the Blind. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Country of the Blind (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of perception and truth. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of perception and truth in The Country of the Blind. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how H. G. Wells's choices in The Country of the Blind (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of perception and truth, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Country of the Blind's treatment of perception and truth in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on perception and truth in The Country of the Blind that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on perception and truth in The Country of the Blind. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about perception and truth in The Country of the Blind, engaging at least

four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on perception and truth in The Country of the Blind, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Conformity

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Country of the Blind teaches about conformity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how H. G. Wells develops conformity in The Country of the Blind. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how H. G. Wells develops conformity across The Country of the Blind. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Country of the Blind (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of conformity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of conformity in The Country of the Blind. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how H. G. Wells's choices in The Country of the Blind (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of conformity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Country of the Blind's treatment of conformity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on conformity in The Country of the Blind that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on conformity in The Country of the Blind. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about conformity in The Country of the Blind, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on conformity in The Country of the Blind, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Arrogance

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Country of the Blind teaches about arrogance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how H. G. Wells develops arrogance in The Country of the Blind. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how H. G. Wells develops arrogance across The Country of the Blind. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Country of the Blind (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of arrogance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of arrogance in The Country of the Blind. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how H. G. Wells's choices in The Country of the Blind (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of arrogance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Country of the Blind's treatment of arrogance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on arrogance in The Country of the Blind that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on arrogance in The Country of the Blind. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on arrogance in The Country of the Blind, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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